

THIS WEEK POURED BY **RIVERSIDE WINE & SPIRITS** · SAMPLE SPONSOR

WINE · BEER · BOURBON · THE TABLE

Mise en Place

Get ready to drink well, pair well, and host well — Chattanooga.

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THE MISE

This started, honestly, with a dinner. Friends coming over, and I needed wine — so I drove to the shop, and forty minutes later I was still there, talking grapes and bourbon and where to eat with people who love this stuff as much as I do. I drove home happy.

That's the whole idea. **Mise en place** is the cook's term for getting everything in its place before the heat comes on — and that's what this is: the weekly that gets you *ready*. The bottle worth seeking, the people behind the counter, what just landed on the shelf, and where to pour it. So the good life at your table is the easy part.

Pull the cork. — [Your Name]

THE POUR

It's July in Tennessee. Chill your reds.

The summer move nobody tells you about: **light reds taste better cold**. Twenty minutes in the fridge tames the alcohol, lifts the fruit, and turns a porch evening around. Ask your shop for a *gamay* (think Beaujolais), a Sicilian *frappato*, or a cool-climate pinot noir — low tannin, high refreshment, perfect with everything off the grill.

Tell the person behind the counter "something I can chill, under \$25, for burgers." That sentence gets you a great bottle every time.

THE SHOP

Imbibe — the Southside shop that thinks like a restaurant

If you want to fall down a good rabbit hole, walk into **Imbibe** on the Southside (1616 Broad St). It's wine-led but built like a chef's pantry — a **tasting bar with daily samples**, a wall of beer on tap you can fill a growler from, and people behind the counter who'd rather ask what you're cooking than point at a shelf. It came out of Chattanooga's fine-dining world, and it shows.

(Confirm current ownership & hours before printing.)

THE MAKER

Bleu Fox — a cheesemonger from the very first class

Jesse and Brittany opened **Bleu Fox Cheese Shop** on East Main in 2017 — but the credential is the tell: Jesse earned his Certified Cheese Professional in **2012, in the program's inaugural class**. That's a cheesemonger who was a pro before "cheesemonger" was a job title here. Grazing boards, 100-plus cheeses, charcuterie to build a night around. The name? Their kids — Amelia **Bleu** and Henry **Fox**.

ON THE SHELF & TAPS

Just landed (3 days ago): Chattanooga Whiskey's Batch Alpha-1, "Comet Crusher" — released June 24 for the distillery's tongue-in-cheek "UFO Day." A sci-fi-themed bourbon liqueur built from 42 ingredients, \$49.99; rolling out to area shops over the coming weeks. (The distillery was just named Whisky Magazine's **2026 Craft Producer of the Year** — and yes, the 14th-Anniversary *Founder's Blend*, solera-finished, may still be findable at \$59.99.)

On tap: Hutton & Smith's Igneous IPA (7.2%, 65 IBU) — pine-and-citrus, biscuity finish, from the climbing-and-geology crew on E. MLK.

The bourbon chase: the names locals watch for allocated bottles are **Riley's** (Hixson) and **Imbibe** (Southside) — the move is to get on a list, not to get lucky walking in. (*Allocation specifics reported historically — confirm current programs.*)

THE TABLE • DRINK WELL

Little Coyote, and the case for a frozen cocktail

Erik Niel's St. Elmo room earned a **Michelin Bib Gourmand** last fall, and the bar is half the reason to go: it leans agave, with a **25-page spirits list** and a frozen "**Texas Flood**" — tequila, blood orange, Aperol, ancho chile. Niel's a two-time James Beard *Best Chef: Southeast* nominee, and his whole-animal butcher shop, **Main Street Meats**, made the Michelin list too. Order the frozen drink. Trust me. (*Verify the cocktail's on the current menu.*)

HOST THIS • FRIENDS COMING OVER?

The easiest win in entertaining is a board and three bottles, set out *before* anyone arrives — mise en place, made literal. One sparkling (it does the welcoming for you), one chillable red (see The Pour), and a three-cheese run from Bleu Fox:

something soft, something sharp, something blue. Put it out, pour yourself one, and answer the door already relaxed. That's the whole trick.

THE CALENDAR · MARK YOUR GLASS

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| Jul 3 | Gate 11 Summer Jazz Night — cocktails + live jazz in the distillery that ages spirits in a boxcar, at the Choo Choo. (<i>confirm date</i>) |
| Sep 19 | Chatta Town Tasting Festival — Chattanooga Green. Free entry; tasting pours \$1–\$10. |
| Sep 26 | Bacon & Barrel — food & whiskey festival, First Horizon Pavilion, 5–8p. |
| Oct 17–18 | Chattanooga Oktoberfest — First Horizon Pavilion. Free; 99+ local & seasonal beers. |
| Ongoing | Hands-on classes — PastaNooga & Sweet & Savory Classroom (BYO wine). Check their booking calendars. |

SPONSOR SLOTS · HOW MEP IS FUNDED (SAMPLE PLACEMENTS)

Presenting sponsor (a bottle shop, rotating) · **Featured Tasting** (an event co-host — a winery, brewery, or class) · **The Good Kinsmen** cookware spot. Every placement labeled; the picks above are never for sale.

Mise en Place

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